

Digital Feminist Humor as a Weapon: A Sentiment and Topic Analysis of the Weibo Posts of the Fat Cat Event

Abstract: In April 2024, game trainer Fat Cat tragically took his own life after being manipulated into living frugally for his girlfriend, which left him unable to afford even basic food. In the wake of his death, many Chinese netizens paid tribute by sending online food deliveries (OFD) to the location of his passing. However, this memorial gesture soon devolved into a contentious debate over gender politics. This study employs sentiment analysis and topic modeling on Weibo posts to explore how an ostensibly neutral act like ordering takeout became imbued with gendered meanings and transformed into a vehicle for socio-political struggle. Initially, the memorial ritual attracted predominantly male participants from the gaming community, inadvertently reinforcing traditional gender norms surrounding men's sacrifice. In response, female netizens challenged the sincerity of these mourning practices, drawing attention to issues such as food waste and gender bias. Through digital feminist humor and critique, they reframed the narrative, exposing the underlying power dynamics. This case study illustrates how digital feminist humor and activism in China can effectively navigate gaps in public discourse to promote gender awareness and counter the influence of the cyber-manosphere.

Keywords: Sentiment analysis, topic modeling, cyber manosphere, feminist activism, digital feminist humor

Introduction

On April 11, 2024, a game trainer nicknamed “Fat Cat” jumped off the Yangtze River Bridge in Chongqing, sparking significant discussion across major Chinese online platforms. The topic “The Fat Cat Incident” on Sina Weibo garnered 1.22 billion views within a month. During this time, the incident transformed from a seemingly random event into a highly contentious issue. This shift led to the emergence of celebratory tributes marked by the keyword “online food deliveries.” Additionally, the incident highlighted critical issues such as gender roles, conflicts, cyber discrimination, and violence against women.

At the outset of the incident, Fat Cat’s sister released chat records indicating that his girlfriend, Tan Zhu, had unilaterally requested favors from him. Netizens identified Tan as the injured party, labeling her a “murderer” and subjecting her to cyber violence. On the other hand, Fat Cat was revered as a “warrior of pure love.”

Our data revealed that users developed metaphors of empathy toward Fat Cat (Lipps 1960; Helen et al. 2016). The discovery of extensive transfer records and indications of gaslighting by his family, juxtaposed with Fat Cat’s frugal lifestyle, elicited sympathy and indignation among netizens. In response, many ordered food and requested it be delivered to the Chongqing Yangtze River Bridge.

Memorial rituals took on a gendered dimension as public opinion evolved. There was a notable divergence in perspectives between male and female participants. Some men

passionately declare that Fat Cat was mistreated. In contrast, female users scrutinized these memorial practices, extending excessive sympathy to men and marginalizing women. The public debate hence intensified, prompting a more comprehensive examination of gender dynamics, power structures, and online public opinion manipulation.

On May 19, the Chongqing police disclosed new details that altered public perception. Contrary to previous allegations, the investigation revealed that Fat Cat and Tan were in a relationship. Furthermore, it became evident that Tan did not deceive Fat Cat or fabricate any information; her actions did not constitute fraud (CCTV News 2024). As the narrative unfolded, it was discovered that Fat Cat's sister had orchestrated a manipulation of public opinion and incited cyber violence against Tan. Soon, the netizens redirected their anger toward this woman again.

This study aims to examine the mechanisms and processes through which customary memorial rituals are appropriated and redefined in the context of gender conflicts. In particular, this investigation will explore how seemingly neutral behaviors are co-opted into broader socio-political struggles, focusing on the digital age where online platforms amplify and perpetuate these dynamics.

Digital Mourning, Gendering of Takeaway in the Fat Cat Incident

Social media has given rise to new forms of digital mourning (Cann 2013). Virtual platforms and social media liberate traditional forms of mourning from spatial and temporal limitations (Moyer and Enck 2020; Walter 2015).

Scholars have investigated digital mourning on Twitter and Facebook (Babis 2021; Moyer and Enck 2020), indicating that social media exhibits greater openness and interactivity (Giaxoglou et al. 2017; Papacharissi 2016). On the one hand, sharing and posting allows individuals to express and retain their grief for the deceased. On the other hand, engaging in online interactions and perusing the posts of others also provides a sense of empowerment. Nevertheless, this form has long been criticized for deviating from the seriousness and intended purpose of mourning (Riechers 2013). Concurrently, it has resulted in incidents such as RIP trolling, defined as the act of individuals posting offensive content on remembrance pages that ridicules or provokes mourners, particularly concerning the performative aspects of public mourning and so-called “mourning tourists” (Seigfried-Spellar and Chowdhury 2017).

However, a phenomenon that has yet to be acknowledged by the academic community is emerging in the context of Fat Cat. The radical development of online food delivery (OFD) has the potential to alter the form of digital mourning while intensifying the extent of its existing criticisms and further exacerbating the issues currently being observed. The rapid expansion of online food delivery (OFD) services in China in recent years has resulted in a significant increase in users, accounting for 50.7% of the urban resident population in 2019 (Meituan Research Institute 2020).

Such services facilitate a more profound connection between mourners and the deceased. They enable mourners to not only express their sentiments and condolences on social media but also to deliver food to the place of mourning online. As elucidated in Candi's study, Chinese funeral customs diverge from those observed in other countries in that they may be marked by highly personalized behaviors, including the provision of the deceased's preferred food and drink from their lifetime as a gesture of goodwill (Cann 2013). In the case of the Fat Cat, netizens, through the disclosure of chat logs, suggested that the person in question had been unable to enjoy even inexpensive fast food due to self-sacrifice during his lifetime. Additionally, he had repeatedly expressed his desire for fast food through social media, which led to his connection with OFD and online mourning. Furthermore, the act fosters a sense of collectivism among mourners, thereby conferring a specific identity and group recognition upon them.

Ordering takeout is not inherently gendered; it is a memorial ritual that any gender can perform. However, as the discussion progressed, the act acquired meanings and characteristics related to gender, becoming a tool and weapon in the ongoing debate about gender discourses. As the event unfolded, we were intrigued to observe how this act became gendered and transformed into a component of activist strategies. This led us to examine the nexus between female online activism and the manosphere on social media.

Manosphere and Misogyny on the Internet

Since its inception, the Internet has served as a privileged sphere for proliferating men's rights activism and the popularization of discourses (Lilly 2016; Schmitz and Kazyak 2016). In the context of the growing popularity of feminist and gender equality agendas online, traditional hegemonic masculinity is facing challenges (Banet-Weiser 2018). The deconstruction of men power dynamics and the dismantling of the rigid norms associated with hegemonic heterosexuality are occurring through the development of societal stages (Carrigan et al. 1985; Han and Yin 2022; Messerschmidt 2018). An emotional "misogyny" emerged among men, including misogynistic ideology, anti-feminist discourse, and related elements of male separatism and males' separatism etc. These individuals do not accept progressive societal changes that indicate greater gender inclusivity and seek to assert their hegemonic masculinity through acts of defiance (Banet-Weiser 2018; Han and Yin 2022).

The term "Manosphere" was subsequently coined. A variety of groups, including the MRAs (Men's Rights Activists), the girl-gazers, the MGOWs (Men Who Go Their Own Way), the men's rights activists, and others, began to argue that feminists were attempting to use "political correctness" to suppress men, thereby causing an "over-feminism" - i.e., a sexist and overreactive response to men that men had to counter (Marwick and Lewis 2017; Marwick and Caplan 2018; Shaw and Mayo 2016). The Manosphere, as an anti-feminist internet community group, features a misogynistic view of women and a rejection of women's "excess of power," resulting in the initiation of cyber abuse, cyber victimization, and cyber hate directed at women (Jane

2017; Van Valkenburgh 2019) and has gradually grown from an internet community group into a symbolic form of movement (Krendel 2020).

The attribution of this “male supremacy” worldview and group formation on the Internet can be traced back to the Men’s Rights Movement (MRM) that began in the 1970s (Messner 1998). However, it is, in essence, a form of oppression and punishment rooted in patriarchal norms and societal power structures and a concrete manifestation of sexism and misogyny against women (Gotell and Dutton 2016; Messner 1998; Rafail and Freitas 2019; Rothermel 2023; Schmitz and Kazyak 2016; Van Valkenburgh 2019). Some scholars have conceptualized the manosphere as a discursive movement of feminist social micropolitics (Jane 2017; Rothermel 2023) entrenched and reproducing itself in Internet space, seeking to view women on the Internet as an incursion into the previously masculine discourse-dominated cyberspace.

The Fat Cat affair can be explicated along the three concepts of “homogeneity, anonymity, and the echo chamber effect” (Van Valkenburgh, 2019) to respectively interpret: why the orgy was engaged in, why the content was produced, and why the polarized viewpoints were generated (Van Valkenburgh, 2019). In Fat Cat’s case, both male and female users were generally “homogeneous” in their arguments, i.e., tending to favor claims that conform to their belief systems and disregarding information from dissenting voices. As such, discourse production within the field is rapidly polarized, with similar views reinforcing each other and opposing views

creating antagonisms. In the Fat Cat incident, Tan was pre-emptively stigmatized from the beginning of the story, and all the tweets and phrases in the media, including the press and independent media, described Fat Cat as a “warrior of pure love” and Tan Zhu as a “gold-digger.” This polarization is because men and women are quickly pitted against each other and pick sides based on their homogeneity. The anonymity of social media exacerbates this. Men’s offline inhibitions are vented online (Jane, 2017), exacerbating the “online de-inhibition effect” (Suler 2004, 321), where men are prone to becoming preoccupied with their social perceptions, and thus accurately generating offensive content against women in the case (Brown et al. 2018; Kohut et al. 2016).

The act in question was imbued with meanings related to gender. We observed this act becoming gendered and transformed into a component of activist strategies, which led us to investigate the nexus between female online activism and the manosphere on social media.

Online Female Activism: Digital Feminist Humor as a counter-strategy

Since social media went viral in 2010, enabling global interconnectivity, women have found male hegemony even more pervasive in cyberspace than in the real world. As a result, feminists have turned their attention to online discourse to raise awareness of issues related to patriarchy, sexism, and misogyny (Harris 2008; Schuster 2014). As women’s power and influence on Internet platforms have grown, women have become aware of the hostility and rancor that occurs on social media and have begun

to counter and take action actively. Women's online activism has also begun to emerge (Banet-Weiser 2018; Crossley 2015; Gillard 2016; Hutton et al. 2016; Kohut et al. 2016; Manago 2013).

Since 2012, online feminist activism has been a highly contentious issue in China. This is due to the emergence of discussions on Weibo about gender inequality and discrimination (Hou 2015; Hou 2020; Yin and Sun 2021). The growing animosity between men and women and the intensifying confrontation between the genders has become a prominent feature of social discourse (Wu and Dong, 2019). Consequently, when public events or contentious issues emerge, Weibo users frequently engage in impassioned discussions pertaining to gender-related matters. Notably, the number of female Weibo users is almost double that of male users and is increasing annually (Yuan et al. 2018). This is similar to how Jane (2017, 186-198) came up with "vigilantism" and "cybervigilante." It is seen as women's revenge against men in the digital domain (Hai-Jew 2015). In 2021, Wu Yifan's sexual assault of a minor sparked a gender conflict on Weibo. A discrepancy in social status and fame led to a disparity in power between the two genders. The victim showed great courage in seeking justice despite harassment online from men and female fans. This female act of retribution was a turning point in social media history. Early feminists in the male circle retweeted a statement perceived as patriarchal, "Women's rights have advanced, and society has recognized them." This led to more challenges for men on Weibo.

As evidenced by the Fat Cat incident, the primary strategy employed by women on Weibo differs from the conventional troll strategy of misogyny. They typically employ a humorous and ironic approach to counteract anti-feminist male hate speech. As J. Gallivan proposed in 1992, this strategy, termed “feminist humor,” differs from the stereotypical mockery of sexism and inequality (Gallivan 1992, 369). Instead, it utilizes irony to expose and criticize sexism and is seen as a way to subvert gender hierarchies and patriarchy (Shifman and Lemish 2010). The advent of social media has also provided an essential platform for the production and dissemination of digital feminist humor. Shifman and Lemish (2010, 255) effectively predicted that the internet could become an ideal medium for feminist humor, describing it as “dedicated to affirming duality, opposition, and empowerment.” The construction and use of feminist memes are potent weapons of feminist cultural critique, often responding in groups, in large spaces, and with a series of memes and ironic discourse in the comments section. Rentschler and Thrift (2015) consider adopting feminist humor as a political model of feminism. Ringrose and Lawrence studied the use of feminist Tumblr memes (2018). Online feminist humor is subjective and open to interpretation. Counterattacks result in provocative actions and shifts in power. This diverts Weibo users from addressing gender rights concerns and causes negative attitudes toward terms like “feminism” and “women’s power.” (Wu and Dong 2019).

Therefore, we would like to explore how the Fat Cat Incident, which did not directly involve gender as a starting point, evolved into a gender war. This incident reveals the current misogynistic environment on Weibo, China’s largest social media platform,

and how women have used digital feminist humor to fight back, which leads to our research questions:

RQ1. How was the term “online food deliveries” gendered in the Weibo discussion of the Fat Cat incident?

RQ2. Within it, how did women act with digital feminist humor?

Method

To comprehensively depict the dynamics of gender politics in Chinese online cyberspace, we conduct an NLP (Natural Language Process) on the food-related posts during the Fat Cat event on Weibo.

Data Collection

The data were collected from Weibo, a major social media platform in China with more balanced gender demographics and where the debates are mainly ongoing. We searched for “Fat Cat” (胖猫) together with food-related keywords in this event (see Table 1) and scraped the search results daily using web crawlers, building our dataset. Our dataset spans May 1st to May 25th, 2024, providing comprehensive coverage of the event’s progression.

Keywords	Translation
外卖	Online food deliveries

华莱士	Wallace ¹
肯德基	KFC
麦当劳	McDonald's
蜜雪冰城	Mixue Bingcheng ²
茶百道	Cha Ba Dao ³

Table 1. *Selected Keywords for Data Collection*

In collecting text data from Weibo, it is worth noting that every user is required to provide gender information, thereby associating each post with a specific user gender. Consequently, during the data collection process, we simultaneously gathered gender information corresponding to each text. Our dataset comprises 5537 posts, with 1316 posts from male users and 4420 from female users.

As depicted in Figure 1, discussions around the “Fat Cat” related to food and online food deliveries on Chinese social media were mainly concentrated in two periods: before May 6th and around May 19th, with relatively fewer discussions in mid-May. Looking from the gender perspective, female users generally made more posts throughout the event, especially from May 2nd to May 12th and around May 19th. The number of posts by female users significantly exceeded those by male users, which, in

¹ *Note:* Chinese fast food brand

² *Note:* Chinese bubble tea brand

³ *Note:* Chinese bubble tea brand

fact, indirectly indicates that the leading group exerting a key influence on public opinion during the event was primarily women.

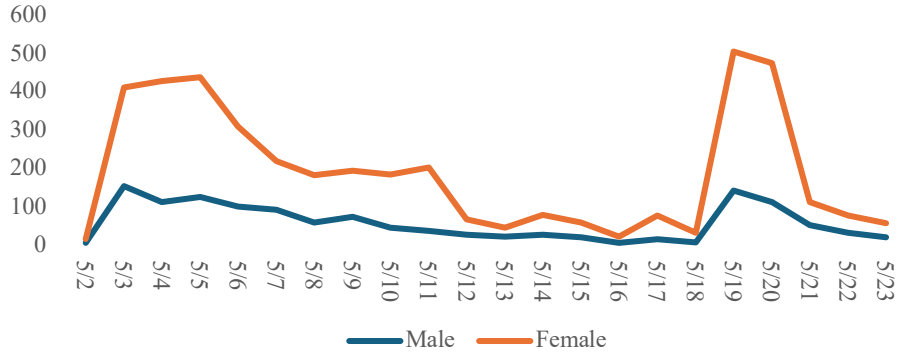


Figure 1. *The Trend of Daily Posts for Different Genders*

Data Preprocessing

Prior to analysis, the raw data underwent a meticulous preprocessing phase, including text cleaning and word segmentation.

Text Content Cleaning.

Since the raw data text contains some noisy information, which interferes with the text's recognition, thus we deleted invalid information such as emojis, symbols, characters, etc. We also eliminated duplicate posts in our dataset to preserve the dataset's integrity and uniqueness. After data preprocessing, this data set covers 5537 posts on the event, which are stored in chronological order, including post-date, post content, number of fans, and users' gender.

Chinese Word Segmentation.

Chinese word segmentation technology divides a sequence of Chinese characters into individual words according to their semantics. Regarding Chinese text segmentation tools, the “jieba” package in Python is widely used and has many advantages, such as adding customized words (Day and Lee 2016; Peng et al. 2017). This research adopts the “jieba” package to perform the Chinese text segmentation task.

Stop Words and Synonym Words.

There are numerous “meaningless” words in Chinese text, including common conjunctions, prepositions, and articles. The words lack inherent significance and are commonly known as stop words. Filtering out these words helps reduce the complexity of the text data, allowing us to focus on the more meaningful content. Additionally, we have identified and standardized synonyms to ensure consistency across the dataset.

Techniques for Data Analysis

Specifically, the research employs two prominent NLP techniques: sentiment analysis and topic modeling.

Sentiment Analysis. Text sentiment analysis is an automated process for examining semantic relationships and the meanings of tweets (Alaei et al. 2019). Critical approaches include lexicon-based, machine-learning, and hybrid methods (Medhat et al. 2014). Lexicon-based methods need a predefined group of lexicons of sentiments used to determine the polarity of a text; this group of lexicons is the emotions in the

text (Saif et al. 2016). Among all the methods, SnowNLP is one of Python's most used class library tools to process Chinese text content, whose main functions include word segmentation, part-of-speech tagging, sentiment analysis, keyword extraction, etc. Chen and Liu (2020) found SnowNLP's sentiment classification accuracy to be 89%, outperforming many classification algorithms in specific contexts. Our study primarily leverages SnowNLP's sentiment analysis to compute and label sentiment scores for each post. We first segment our dataset by gender and time, then analyze overall sentiment trends by gender during the event. This aims to examine if gendered perspectives on OFD behavior exist in the online public opinion space, verifying the event's gendering.

Topic Modelling. Topic modeling is an unsupervised machine-learning technique that identifies primary topics or themes within a collection of unstructured documents (Blei et al. 2003; Blei et al. 2010; Blei and Lafferty 2006; Blei and Lafferty 2007; Chaney and Blei 2021). It views the textual documents as a corpus of multiple topics, each represented by specific words. By transforming the textual document into the mathematical framework, topic modeling tries to discover clusters of word distributions representing overall themes within the corpus, making it a valuable technique for analyzing large datasets for their content.

The mathematical goal of topic modeling is to fit a model's parameters to the given data using heuristic rules, maximizing the likelihood that the data originates from the model. Such methods are parametric methods, among which Latent Dirichlet

Allocation (LDA) is by far the most popular. Due to LDA's inherently non-deterministic and statistical nature, methodological decisions related to data preprocessing, selecting the number of topics, fine-tuning the algorithm's hyperparameters, and evaluating the model's results become significantly more critical (Maier et al. 2018).

This research applies LDA to extract topics from the cleaned dataset with the Python package "SK-learn." Perplexity (lower is better) and coherence (higher is better) scores guide topic number selection (Blei et al. 2003). After identifying the optimal model, "pyLDAvis" is adopted to visualize the topic extraction results, with a coordinate graph to show the topic distributions and list the top 25 salient words for each topic. Topic labels are manually assigned based on these words.

We used topic modeling to identify all possible topics related to the memorial ritual in the Weibo public opinion during the event. Then, two Chinese coders named these themes based on the top 25 keywords and the ten typical posts of each topic. Based on that, we explored and discussed the discursive construction strategies of different genders in the event concerning the memorial act itself.

Result

Sentiment Analysis

Based on the dataset analysis from May 1st to May 25th, 2024, using the SnowNLP model, a line chart was generated, as shown in Figure 2.

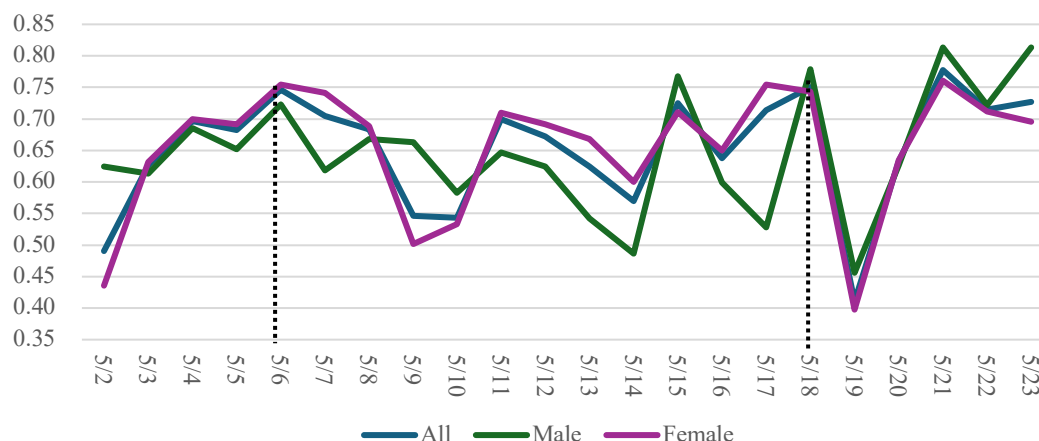


Figure 2. *The Trend of Average Sentiment Index During the event*

From early May, following the initial posts by Fat Cat’s sister detailing her brother’s tragic tale, a fervent wave of discussion surged across the Chinese internet, accompanied by a significant spike in the sentiment index of the posted content. The phenomenon of ordering takeout as a commemorative ritual to honor the so-called “pure love warrior,” Fat Cat, gained momentum, with an increasing number of individuals partaking in this act of remembrance.

Between May 2nd and 6th, the narrative’s multiple reversals fuelled a growing online discussion, driving the sentiment index higher with each twist. It culminated in a peak on May 6th. Remarkably, the emotional trends among male and female users were similar throughout this period, showing a consistent upward trend.

However, from May 7th to 18th, there was a noticeable divergence in sentiment between male and female users, with significant fluctuations in the overall sentiment

index. During this period, gender antagonism on the Chinese internet intensified sharply, leading to a surge in hate speech and confrontational comments.

Not until May 19, when the official statement elucidated the intricacies of the Fat Cat incident, did male and female sentiment trends realign. Following the report, however, the sentiment index plummeted to its lowest point, and the fervor gradually subsided over the next two days, reflecting the profound psychological impact of the truth.

In conclusion, sentiment analysis reveals the event's progression, in which emotions between male and female users were polarized, and the differences in attitudes between them became more and more pronounced. This result also shows that the differences in the discussion and attitude of the memorial ritual of OFD are widening and that a confrontation between gender discourses is emerging.

Topic Analysis

To determine the optimal number of topics, we conducted experiments with topic values ranging from 1 to 30 and generated a consistency curve fit. Based on the results, 20 topics were identified as the most suitable for analysis. **Appendix 1.** illustrates the top 15 words with the highest frequency associated with each of the 20 topics.

As shown in Figure 3, pyLDAvis visualized the result of 20 topics. Topics closer together are more similar in terms of the words they contain. According to the

visualization result, our study generalized seven main clusters of 20 topics. From the 7 clusters, we can conclude how the food relates to gender and how male and female users weaponized the discourse of OFD in this event.



Figure 3. *The Results of Topic Modelling Visualized by pyLDavis Package*

Manosphere: Subtle Signs of Gendered Connotations.

According to his sister, Fat Cat was deeply affectionate, living frugally to buy gifts and transfer funds to his girlfriend, Tan Zhu, yet unable to afford low-cost online food deliveries. In China, ordering online deliveries has long been seen as a sign of frugality. His habit of low-cost food starkly contrasts with his sacrifices to save money for his girlfriend, which touched many netizens.

As a tribute, many users began placing food deliveries on the bridge from which he leaped in early May, initially viewed as a sincere way of honoring him, reflecting admiration, a yearning for true love, and empathy for his situation.

In fact, money issues in intimate relationships and male economic responsibility have been among China's most debated gender topics recently, making many men especially sensitive about these topics. The Fat Cat incident quickly arouses discussion among male netizens on topics such as gold-diggers, AA (going Dutch) payment, Valentine's gifts, and misandry. Under polarized opinions, these discussions quickly evolved into a witch hunt against gold-diggers (Topic 8) and, conversely, excessive denigration and misogyny toward women (Topic 12).

Witch Hunt for "Gold Digger"

Initially, the OFD memorial ritual merely expressed mourning and remembrance. However, after chat records revealed one-way financial transactions from Fat Cat to his girlfriend, Tan Zhu, some netizens began to criticize her acts of economic control to Fat Cat. They labeled her a "gold digger" and, under the guise of commemoration, initiated a witch hunt against her. Numerous netizens subjected Tan Zhu to cyberbullying, directly overwhelming her and causing her to halt her work temporarily. Furthermore, under this topic, many men escalated their hatred to include broader societal norms and even all women.

Anti-misandry

With the rise of feminist activism in China, the concept of misandry has also provoked significant backlash from men's rights activists. The Fat Cat incident provided a good case of a supposedly greedy, male-dependent, malicious woman,

which contrasts sharply with contemporary feminist narratives. This case gave them a pretext to attack both misandry and feminism. In Topic 12, some radical male netizens leveraged the case of Tan Zhu to criticize the current feminist movement, creating a battleground for a subsequent hate war between male and female users online. Within these discussions, many male users utilized the commemoration of Fat Cat to critique and reflect on the societal norm that expects men to bear more financial responsibility for women.

Initially, in male discourse, online food deliveries were originally intended to highlight the public's sympathy and pity for Fat Cat. The OFD memorial ritual was meant to express public nostalgia, regret for the Fat Cat, and respect for the pure love story. However, as this symbol has been increasingly polarized within the manosphere, its narratives have also exhibited subtle signs of gendered connotations.

Desecration: Redefining, Gendering, and Labeling the Memorial Ritual

In the early stages, this memorial ritual was not gendered, and even many female users actively participated in the commemoration of Fat Cat. However, by early May, the public began to reflect on the ritual itself, significantly diminishing its sanctity and creating a space for discussion. It was primarily through feminist activism that the logical inconsistencies and gender politics underlying this commercial ritual were exposed, framing it within gender political discourse. Feminists on Weibo identified the excessive preference for male sacrifice and the dominance of male discourse behind this behavior. As a result, the issue became a focal point of contention,

evolving into a verbal conflict between male and female users and contributing to a broader gender antagonism on the internet.

Topics 1, 2, 6, 11, 14, 17, 16, and 18, predominantly concentrated in the early phase, illustrate how this commemorative ritual transitioned from a non-gendered issue to a gendered one.

De-sacralization: Reflection on the Commemoration

In early May, several beverage delivery stores near Chongqing's Yangtze River Bridge began substituting drinks with plain water for orders directed to the bridge, aiming to reduce food waste. When this practice was revealed, it sparked a significant public backlash.

However, this revelation prompted some netizens to question the purpose behind this commemorative act. First, a debate emerged over whether "Fat Cat" truly warranted such homage. Topic 17 examined the event's authenticity and reviewed chat logs that Fat Cat's sister shared. Secondly, there was a discussion on whether this ritualistic ordering of takeout, indeed, as this brand says, really constituted a waste of food and public resources. Keywords like "wasting food," "sanitation workers," and "public resources" in Topic 2 pointed towards this issue.

As these reflections grew, the sanctity of the ritualistic behavior of ordering takeout and the idolization of Fat Cat as what many called a "pure love warrior" began to diminish.

Demonization: Labelling and Redefining the Memorial Ritual

As the de-sacralization progressed, increasingly hostile labels began to be attached to this memorial ritual of OFD. Some users started questioning whether Fat Cat, merely an ordinary person rather than a celebrity, truly warranted such extensive mourning (Topic 16), which later expanded into broader debates on the event itself (Topic 1). Meanwhile, others diminished the ritual's sanctity, suggesting it was just a way for people to seek attention. Netizens questioned the sincerity of participants, noting that *“many chose the cheaper Wallace instead of paying the 9-yuan delivery fee for McDonald's”* or *“only sent low-cost milk tea brands like Mi Xue Bing Cheng and Cha Bai Dao”* (Topic 18).

Additionally, many realized that there are other similar victims in society harmed by gaslighting who have not received the same attention, further questioning the authenticity and purity of this event (Topic 16). Notably, at this stage, there was still little mention of gender issues; the focus remained on criticizing the memorial behavior itself. Compared to Topics 2 and 17, these discussions became more polarized, with many irrational and overly reflective comments.

Gendering: Reflection became a war of words

Initially, the Fat Cat incident was not linked to gender labels. Its uniqueness lies in Fat Cat's professional identity and community affiliation. He was a professional booster in the *Honor of Kings* gaming community, helping players improve their accounts for payment. This background drew initial memorials from the Chinese esports community, which first promoted the idea of ordering takeout in his honor. Notably, the Chinese esports community is typically male-dominated, with discourse largely

led by male voices. Keywords in Topic 11, such as “Honor of Kings,” “gaming,” “boosting,” and “Meng Qi” (a character Fat Cat often played), reflect this demographic.

However, reflections primarily from female users led to conflicts with the male-dominated memorial participants. As the male dominance in the gaming community was challenged, hate speech and gender antagonism quickly surfaced. Female users mocked those ordering takeout for Fat Cat, calling them “Fat Otakus” (a derogatory term for socially isolated male gamers). In response, men labeled women as “Lao Nv” (a slur implying women are gold-diggers). This development not only gendered the event but also intensified male-female conflicts.

As narratives between male and female users polarized further, Topic 6 turned into a war of words focused on the memorial acts. Mockery and anger grew in Topic 6, with female users comparing Fat Cat to “Qu Yuan” and joking that they would “steal the offerings” to feed themselves. From this perspective, the sanctity of the memorial behavior was entirely eroded, and a distinctly gendered tone emerged.

Feminist Activism: Digital Feminist Humour as a Strategy of Resistance

Digital feminist humor is seen as a critical strategy through which various forms of feminism confront misogyny and sexism. Unlike sexist jokes, feminist humor aims to expose and critique sexism through satire (J. Gallivan 1992).

During this event, female users did not merely verbally confront men. However, they actively leveraged the logical flaws inherent in the memorial ritual to create numerous satirical feminist pieces based on the discursive practices on the Weibo platform. This strategy not only helped challenge the current online bias towards male power and prompted a reconsideration of the present state of the manosphere in the digital environment but, more importantly, accelerated the dissemination of redefined female perspectives and feminist narratives on this platform. As a result, female discourse gained the power to define this ritual within a broader social context.

Label the insincerity to Men

In Topics 19 and 20, many female users widely shared humorous posts that employed irony and contrast to mock and label modern males' stubbornness as linked to pride.

A female Weibo user remarked, *'I understand you, Mr. Handsome ... You say all pretty women are prostitutes but secretly look for ways to sell your dick ... You claim to sympathize with Fat Cat and want to punish so-called gold diggers, but you even have to use credit services to afford a 15-yuan cup of milk tea ...'*

The post exaggeratedly depicted a hypocritical and stingy male who commemorated Fat Cat and moved himself, emphasizing male insincerity. Meanwhile, the post actively reclaimed the gender of the ritual's participants, turning gender-neutral inquiries into strong male stereotypes. This highlighted contradictions in male views on gender issues and raised female awareness of the ritual by mocking men'

inconsistency on different social issues related to gender. Consequently, the post created humor, fostering empathy and encouraging widespread sharing among female users. This, in turn, created a strong sense of solidarity among female users, as Rentschler (2015) and Thrift (2014) discovered.

Mocking Male's Susceptibility to Manipulation

The official announcement revealed that financial transactions between Tan Zhu and Fat Cat were mutual, not one-sided. This reversal diminished the incident's purity, Fat Cat's sanctity, and Tan Zhu's guilt. As public opinion calmed, many reflected on their previous memorial rituals based on official findings (*extracted from Topic 3*).

Within the discussions, some female users began to capitalize on their early advantage in the reflection process, portraying themselves as rational and insightful. Some even escalated this to a disdain for male, criticizing their susceptibility to manipulation and emotionality (Topic 13/7). Female users created propaganda articles about Fat Cat using quotes from "brain-dead fans⁴." These were used to satirize the male users' nearly religious adoration of Fat Cat, thereby demeaning the fervor of Fat Cat's fans (Topic 15).

"The World's Top River-Jumping Warrior [Fat Cat] / Only at twenty-one, he holds dual luxury endorsements with [Cha Ba Dao and Wallace] / Pure Love Warrior / National Mengqi Player / McDonald's Underworld Regional

⁴ *Note:* a term used in the Chinese online environment to describe the most irrational and fanatical followers of celebrities

Promotion Ambassador /Such a great boy, love him is never a loss.” (from Topic 15)

Idol worship has been a critical critique by Chinese men against women. Female users exploited idol worship in the ritual, creating fan comments in a man’s voice. This countered long-standing stereotypes of women and spread quickly on Weibo, a hub for fan culture. Consequently, this humor became mainstream discourse questioning such critiques.

Relating to other Gender Role Reversal events

As previously mentioned, a major criticism of this event is online public opinion’s excessive romanticization of an ordinary love story. During the Fat Cat incident, similar cases with reversed gender roles, such as the Hua Shaobei (male) - Jian Dan (female) event, were noted⁵. In this case, the woman also made significant economic and emotional sacrifices out of love for the man. Yet, the event did not receive much attention, and the male perpetrator did not face strong public condemnation. This has led many female users to question, “*Why doesn't anyone order takeout for the female version of Fat Cat?*” Some female users also expressed a desire for “*Hua Shaobei should go to hell to accompany Fat Cat.*” These statements urged reflection on the performative motives behind such incidents (Topic 9).

⁵ Note: In May 2024, Chinese game streamer Hua Shaobei was embroiled in a scandal when his ex-girlfriend Jian Dan disclosed their seven-year secret relationship. Jian Dan also revealed she had led his fan community for a long time without compensation due to his gaslighting. She claimed Hua Shaobei concealed their relationship to maintain his public image. The revelations drew widespread attention, with reactions ranging from support for Jian to defending Hua’s privacy.

Some users have drawn parallels between this case and past events that also led to public outpourings, such as the Gao Yan incident involving the LGBTQ community, the Kobe Bryant crash primarily involving men, and the Zhong Ni and Mocha incidents involving heterosexuals. They mocked the focus on the “affectionate male image” and satirized public over-empathy towards the Fat Cat incident (Topic 10).

“I suggest that our government establish a Rose Festival to commemorate Gao Yan, a Strawberry Festival to commemorate Mocha, an Ocean Festival to commemorate Zhong Ni, a McDonald’s Festival to commemorate Fat Cat, and a Kobe Festival to commemorate Kobe Bryant, with free flights for all.” (Topic 10)

However, some male users still strive to uphold the sanctity and legitimacy of the incident and Fat Cat, arguing that, regardless of the truth, Fat Cat has undoubtedly contributed more financially and, in this case, even paid with his life. Therefore, his victimhood and the fact that he experienced gaslighting are beyond doubt.

Consequently, they refute the public (predominantly female users) for belittling and mocking the memorial rituals. Some of these counterarguments have even escalated into accusations of “misandry” against women (Topics 5 and 4).

During the months following the event, these instances of digital feminist humor continued circulating on the Chinese internet, garnering significant attention and engagement. This highlighted digital feminist humor’s potential as a powerful feminist tool. Using satire and irony to expose and critique gender biases, these

humorous pieces resonated widely, reaching audiences beyond the immediate participants of the Fat Cat incident.

The Fat Cat incident has been completely turned into an internet meme, with OFD even symbolizing the mockery and humor associated with this event. Amid the prolific creation of digital feminist humor, these discourses have continually spread to other communities and platforms, such as Douyin and *Kuai*, reminding more and more people to reflect on the excessive glorification of male sacrifice behind the incident.

Discussion

The Fat Cat case shows how Chinese digital feminist activists use logical gaps in public discourse to advance feminist activism and counter the cyber-manosphere. Our empirical sentiment and topic analysis confirm their strategies.

Initially, ordering takeout became a neutral way to memorialize the deceased in the digital mourning surrounding this incident. Most attention came from male gamers within the predominantly male gaming community, a typical manosphere in China, and the memorial activities were largely male-led. Online food delivery (OFD) to honor the deceased has recently become normalized among men. In contrast, female netizens criticized this practice, highlighting its inconsistencies. The deceased was notable for relinquishing traditional male advantages in a romantic relationship, which led male netizens to depict him as a victim of manipulation and label him a “pure love

warrior.” This narrative resonated within the male-dominated gaming community, reinforcing traditional gender norms regarding male sacrifice and victimhood.

Female netizens carefully scrutinized the event and began questioning the sanctity of the ritual and the figure being memorialized. As the critique deepened, concerns regarding food waste—a long-standing negative aspect of OFD memorial practices—took center stage. Ultimately, the sanctity of the figure known as The Fat Cat also came under scrutiny, exposing issues related to his gender identity and the preferential treatment he received from the manosphere. Women redefined the event by introducing gendered labels and utilizing digital feminist humor. They pointedly mocked insincerity, critiqued male stinginess and susceptibility to control, and inverted traditional gender roles to illuminate the unique gender politics at work. Through these actions, they transformed the memorial ritual into a performance that highlighted male gender dynamics, effectively exposing the underlying biases and power structures involved.

The effectiveness of digital feminist humor lies in its ability to engage a diverse audience, making complex feminist critiques accessible and relatable. It encourages critical thinking and reflection on societal norms, prompting discussions that might otherwise be avoided or overlooked. Furthermore, the viral nature of such content on social media platforms ensures that feminist messages can spread rapidly and widely, amplifying their impact.

In this context, digital feminist humor serves not only as a means of resistance but also as a form of empowerment. It allows women to reclaim narratives and challenge patriarchal structures in an impactful and culturally resonant way. The success of these satirical pieces underscores the importance of creative and innovative approaches in advancing feminist discourse in the digital age. By leveraging digital feminist humor, activists can further solidify its role as a cornerstone of modern feminist strategy, using it to drive social change and promote gender equality across various digital landscapes.

Conclusion

The Fat Cat case illuminates how gender, technology, and public discourse converge. It also shows how digital mourning can be re-defined in the context of gender conflicts. By examining this case, we gain a deeper understanding of the implications for contemporary gender activism. Furthermore, the gendering of the memorial reflects broader challenges in China. In the context of the manosphere, women are defending their rights, while men's rights groups respond with slogans that distort feminist activism. Gender dynamics and traditionalism continue to shape the discourse. Challenging patriarchy and disseminating feminist perspectives in the digital age requires flexible and strategic feminist activism. Further research should examine how gender activism interacts with technology and public discourse in different cultures and contexts. This could help us understand how to address gender biases in diverse digital environments and advance gender equity in the digital age.

Disclosure statement

The authors declare that they have no conflict of interest.

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Appendix1. Result of Topic Modelling and Top 15 words for each topic

Topic #	Top 15 Words	Translation
1	哭坟 高彦 玫瑰 草莓 仲尼 墨茶 麦当劳 复活 科比 茶百道 行程 王者荣耀 华莱士 饺子 降半旗	Crying at Grave, Gao Yan (Person), Rose, Strawberry, Zhong Ni (Person), Mocha (Person), McDonald's (Brand), Resurrection, Kobe Bryant (Person), Cha Bai Dao (Brand), Itinerary, Honor of Kings (Game), Wallace (Brand), Dumplings, Half-mast
2	外卖 胖猫姐姐 浪费粮食 视频 网友 事件 环卫工人 证明 影响 食物 地址 鲜花 公共资源 直播 社会	Online food deliveries, Fat Cat's Sister (Person), Wasting Food, Video, Netizens, Incident, Sanitation Workers, Prove, Impact, Food, Address, Flowers, Public Resources, Livestream, Society
3	警方通报 情况 外卖 奶茶 纯爱战神 谭竹 对方网暴 男女 官方通报 深情 笑话 好人 女主 金钱	Police Report, Situation, Online food deliveries, Milk Tea, Pure Love Warrior, Tan Zhu (Person), Cyberbullying, Gender, Official Report, Deep Affection, Joke, Good Person, Female Lead, Money
4	事件 外卖 空包 小时 品牌 舆情 网友 脑子 妻子 企业 粉丝 链接 网页 妹妹 消费者	Incident, Online food deliveries, Empty Package, Hour, Brand, Public Opinion, Netizens, Brain, Wife, Enterprise, Fans, Link, Webpage, Sister, Consumer

5	麦当劳 套餐 谭竹 十块 钱 产品 名字 活动 出租 屋 同学 用户 火化 快餐 全网 地址 集美	McDonald's (Brand), Set Meal, Tan Zhu (Person), Ten Yuan, Product, Name, Activity, Rental House, Classmate, User, Cremation, Fast Food, Internet, Address, Beautiful Girl (Net slang)
6	外卖 全国 祭品 冷暴力 屈原 全网 互联网 朋友 女友 伤心 建议 性别 复 活 黄浦江 跳河	Online food deliveries, Nationwide, Offering, Cold Violence, Qu Yuan (Person), Internet, Friend, Girlfriend, Sad, Suggestion, Gender, Resurrection, Huangpu River, Jumping into River
7	麦当劳 名单 外卖 晚安 姐妹 痞幼 头像 天堂 网 红 官方 事件 商业 稿件 企业 智商	McDonald's (Brand), List, Takeout, Good Night, Sister, Piyo (Internet Celebrity), Avatar, Heaven, Internet Celebrity, Official, Incident, Commercial, Article, Enterprise, Intelligence
8	人家 外卖 神经 结果 孩 子 投胎 五二零 关心 网 络 通报 离谱 肚子 正义 小心 拜金	People, Online food deliveries, Nerves, Result, Child, Reincarnation, May 20th (Internet Slang), Care, Internet, Report, Absurd, Belly, Justice, Careful, Gold Digger (Net slang)
9	外卖 热度 鲜花 花少北 事发地 时间 煎蛋 教程 评论 原因 聊天记录 视 频 博主 网红 环境	Online food deliveries, Popularity, Flowers, Hua Shaobei (Person), Incident Location, Time, Fried Egg, Tutorial, Comment, Reason, Chat Record, Video, Blogger, Internet Celebrity, Environment

10	纪念 建议 免费 麦当劳 国家 墨茶 草莓 仲尼 坐 飞机 科比 玫瑰 高彦 调 休 集体 屈原	Memorial, Suggestion, Free, McDonald's (Brand), Country, Mocha (Person), Strawberry, Zhong Ni (Person), Airplane Ride, Kobe (Person), Rose, Gao Yan (Person), Compensatory Leave, Collective, Qu Yuan (Person)
11	名字 王者荣耀 游戏 代 练 跳河 男友 弟弟 梦奇 地方 麦当劳 勇士 纯爱 战神 姐姐 谭竹 使用者	Name, Honor of Kings (Game), Game, Boosting, Jumping into River, Boyfriend, Younger Brother, Mengqi (Game Character), Place, McDonald's (Brand), Warrior, Pure Love Warrior, Sister, Tan Zhu (Person), User
12	外卖 谭竹 十块钱 事件 女友 胖猫姐姐 警方 朋 友圈 关系 父母 花钱 情 侣 姐姐 财产 妈妈	Online food deliveries, Tan Zhu (Person), Ten Yuan, Incident, Girlfriend, Fat Cat's Sister (Person), Police, Friends Circle, Relationship, Parents, Spend Money, Couple, Sister, Property, Mother
13	捞女 奶茶 女友 兄弟 现 实 女孩 定义 伟人 男同 男权 家属 全球 部分 年 轻人 婚恋观	Gold Digger (Net Slang), Milk Tea, Girlfriend, Brother, Reality, Girl, Definition, Great Person, Male Homosexual, Male Rights, Family, Global, Part, Young People, View on Love and Marriage
14	华莱士 麦当劳 支持 评 论 捞男 店里 配送费 外 卖员 公关 理由 图片 站 队 营销 评价 一堆人	Wallace (Brand), McDonald's (Brand), Support, Comment, Gold Digger (Net slang), In the Store, Delivery Fee, Delivery person, Public Relations, Reason, Picture, Taking

		Sides, Marketing, Review, A Bunch of People (Net Slang)
15	纯爱战神 男孩 梦奇 麦 当劳 国服 茶百道 华莱 士 阴间 代言 大使 人生 下家 区域 冲锋 五跳一	Pure Love Warrior, Boy, Mengqi (Game Character), McDonald's (Brand), National Server, Cha Bai Dao (Brand), Wallace (Brand), Underworld, Endorsement, Ambassador, Life, Next Person, Region, Charge, Five Jumps One (Net slang)
16	华莱士 网友 蜜雪冰城 热搜 空包 茶百道 明星 商家 回家 下家 员工 跳 河 火化 螺蛳粉 垃圾	Wallace (Brand), Netizens, Mixue Bingcheng (Brand), Hot Search, Empty Package, Cha Bai Dao (Brand), Celebrity, Merchant, Go Home, Next Person, Employee, Jumping into River, Cremation, Snail Noodles, Garbage
17	事件 女主 舆论 网暴 生 活 生命 感情 网红 死者 家人 世界 网友 立案 爱 情 前任	Incident, Female Lead, Public Opinion, Cyberbullying, Life, Emotions, Internet Celebrity, Deceased, Family, World, Netizens, Case Filing, Love, Ex
18	茶百道 奶茶 麦当劳 肯 德基 外卖 手机 曝光 苹 果手机 三观 礼貌 高质 量 支持 名义 咖啡 媚男	Cha Bai Dao (Brand), Milk Tea, McDonald's (Brand), KFC (Brand), Takeout, Mobile Phone, Expose, iPhone (Brand), Values, Manners, High Quality, Support, Name, Coffee, Male Pleaser (Net slang)

19	世界 工作 奶茶 捞女 美 女 鸡巴 制裁 私下 渠道 月薪 大专 老师 英语 洋 媳妇 集帅	World, Work, Milk Tea, Gold Digger (Net Slang), Beauty, Dick, Punish, Privately, Channel, Monthly Salary, Junior College, Teacher, English, Foreign Wife, Ji Shuai (Net slang)
20	共情 奶茶 医院 女孩 游 戏 人家 好下场 律师 对 象 衣服 普信男 表情 官 方 集美 风波	Empathy, Milk Tea, Hospital, Girl, Game, People, Bad Ending, Lawyer, Partner, Clothes, Ordinary Guy (Net slang), Expression, Official, Beautiful Girl (Net slang), Incident